Brussels Sprouts

By Andy Griffiths

(Pg 16 -34)

ANDY: I'm sitting at the kitchen table with Dad and Jen. Mom is serving dinner. She puts a plate down in front of me. I look at it. Roast chicken. Good. Gravy. Good. Roast potatoes. Good. Brussels sprouts. Bad. FIVE OF THEM! Bad. Bad. Bad. Bad. Bad. I hate brussels sprouts.

And when I say I hate brussels sprouts, I don't just mean I hate brussels sprouts. I mean I REALLY hate brussels sprouts. And when I say I REALLY hate brussels sprouts, I mean I really, really, really, REALLY, REALLY, REALLY hate Brussel sprouts.

Who wouldn't hate them? They're green. They're slimy. They're moldy. They're horrible. They're putrid. They're foul. Apart from that, I love them.

No. I don't. That was just a joke. There's absolutely NOTHING to love about brussels sprouts. Nothing at all. They're disgusting. So why did my mom have to go and spoil a perfectly good roast chicken dinner by giving me FIVE?? Surely she can't possibly expect me to EAT them.

INTRODUCTION

Despite its faithful appearance on holidays, the brussels sprout is the American vegetable villain. This role used to be played by spinach, until Popeye rescued it in the 1930s. A 2008 survey by Heinz shows that brussels sprouts now take the most-hated prize for Americans in general and they consistently make it to the top five in surveys of the most-hated vegetables around the world. Brussels Sprouts by Andy Griffiths

MOM: Come on, Andy. Don't just sit there looking at your dinner. Eat up.

ANDY: All of it?

MOM: *(firmly)* All of it.

ANDY: Even the brussels sprouts?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MOM: Even the brussels spouts.

ANDY: I can't believe it. She DOES expect me to eat them. *(To Mom)* But I HATE brussels sprouts.

MOM: Okay. Suit yourself. But if you don't eat all of your brussels sprouts, you won't get any dessert.

ANDY: Huh? No dessert? If there's one thing I love, it's dessert. And when I say I love dessert, I don't just mean I love dessert. I mean I REALLY love dessert. And no pile of brussels sprouts is going to stop me from getting it, that's for sure. *(To Mom)* But that's not fair!

DAD: If you don't eat your dinner, you don't get dessert. That's the deal. You know that.

ANDY: Some deal. I never had a say in it. As if I'd agree to a stupid deal like that. Jen snickers. She pokes her fork into a brussels sprout and raises it to her lips.

JEN: Mmmmmmmm! (Puts the sprout into her mouth and acts like it's the most beautiful thing she's ever tasted) You don't know what you're missing, Andy.

ANDY: *(to audience)* I know she's just trying to annoy me, but it gives me an idea. *(to family)* OH NO! *(Pointing out the kitchen window)* I DON'T BELIEVE IT!

MOM: What is it? Is that cat back again?

DAD: Are the birds on my new lawn?

JEN: Is it Craig? But he said he wasn't coming until later! I can't let him see me like this!

ANDY: *(to audience and in pantomime)* While they're all staring out of the window trying to figure out what I've seen, I take one of my sprouts and slip it onto Jen's p lat. It's too easy, really. *(to family)* Just kidding! *(to audience)* Mom sighs and Dad shakes his head.

JEN: Are you going to be an idiot all your life?

ANDY: Probably. The pay's a little low, but the hours are good . . . and you can pretty much work whenever you want. *(To audience)* She ignores my reply, stabs the sprout I just put on her plate, and puts it into her mouth. Do I feel ay pity for her? No. I do not. She deserves it. One down. For to go.

DAD: Excuse me, funny boy. Would you mind passing me the pepper?

ANDY: I look at the pepper grinder. I hate pepper. It always makes me sneeze. *(suddenly gets*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

an idea) Of course! Pepper! Sneezing! The oldest trick in the book! Why didn't I think of it sooner? *(to Dad)* Sure *(quickly putting a brussels sprout into his mouth then launching a fake sneeze)* Ah . . . . *(grabs a tissue out of his pocket)* AH . . . . *(holds the tissue up to his face)* AH-CHOOO! *(Spits the brussels sprout into the tissue and quickly puts the whole thing back in his pocket)*

MOM: Bless you.

ANDY: Thanks. I think some pepper got up my nose. *(to audience)* I got away with it again. I quickly shovel some chicken, gravy and potato into my mouth to get rid of the taste of the sprout. Two down. Three to go. I feel something nudge my foot. Sooty! He's not supposed to be in the kitchen while we're eating, but he's managed to sneak in and hide underneath the table anyway. Which is fantastic, because Sooty eats anything. Even brussels sprouts. *(in words and pantomime)* I hunch forward over my plate, conceal one of the sprouts in the palm of my hand and sneak it uner the table to Sooty's waiting wet mouth. Yes! He's eating it! Good dog! He'll be able to eat the other two for me as well. *(reacts to smell)* Suddenly the most disgusting, eye-watering smell fills the kitchen. Mom looks at dad *(Give a Mom look)*. Dad looks at me *(Give a Dad look).* I look at Jen *(maybe points)* We all shrug. *(Shrug)* Dad looks under the table.

DAD: How did that dog get in her?

ANDY: Dad chases him and shoes him out the back door. Darn. Just when I was so close!

JEN: I bed Andy let him in. He's probably been giving him food under the table.

ANDY: Yeah, right. As if!

DAD: You haven't been wasting good food on that mongrel, have you?

ANDY: *(to Dad)* No. *(to audience)* I'm not lying, either. Whatever brussels sprouts are, they are definitely NOT good food. I eat the rest of my dinner and try to figure out how to get rid of the two remaining sprouts. I can't put any more on Jen's plat because she's already finished hers. She'd be sure to notice. And I can't sneeze again because my one tissue is already full. And how's going to help me now that Sooty's gone? *(thinking for a beat)* I know! The X-Men. My X-Men undies, that is. It's going to take a little skill to do it without anybody

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

seeing me, but I think it's possible. *(in words and pantomime)* I tab the next-to-last sprout with my fork, and as I bring it up to my mouth, I stretch open the front of my pants with my other hand. Then, just as I'm about to put the sprout into my mouth, I ease it off the end of my fork with my thumb. It drops down, straight into my undies. A direct hit!

Sure, it feels disgusting, but I'd rather have a brussels sprout squishing around in my undies than squishing around in my stomach. For down, one to go. But this one's not going to be a problem. There's a pile of chicken bones on my plate. I can just hit it under there. Then all I have to do is scrape the sprout off my plate and into the mulch can and the nightmare will be over. Here goes. *(to Mom)* Thanks, Mom. That was delicious. I'll just clear the table. *(Starting to do so)*

JEN: What? You NEVER clear the table.

MOM: Not so fast, Andy. You haven't quite finished.

ANDY: *(innocently after shooting Jen a drop dead look)* What do you mean? I've only got bones left. You can't expect me to eat bones.

MOM: It's not the bones I'm talking about. It's the brussels sprout underneath them.

ANDY: What brussels sprout? Ohhhh *(acting surprised)* THAT brussels sprout! I didn't see it there.

MOM: *(tilts head and raises eyebrows)* Do I look like I was born yesterday?

ANDY: Well, actually, you do look very young for someone so old.

MOM: Nice try, Andy. Sit down and finish your dinner.

ANDY: But I can't eat any more. You gave me too many brussels sprouts.

MOM: I gave you the same as everyone else.

ANDY: But everyone else is bigger than me. I should get less!

DAD: No, you should get more. *(flexing his muscles)* Don't you want to grow up to be as big and strong as me?

ANDY: I AM big and strong. *(family laughs)* What's so funny?

JEN: Your arms are like toothpicks and your legs are like broomsticks. If the wind blows too hard, you fall over. You're a WEED!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ANDY: And you're a pig!

JEN: Than you. You just called me a P-I-G. That stands for Pretty Intelligent Girl.

ANDY: No it doesn't. I stands for Putrid Idiotic Geek!

DAD: Ignore him, Jen. Andy, just shut up and eat your sprout.

ANDY: I can't. I'm full.

MOM: What a shame. You won't be able to hae any dessert.

ANDY: No dessert. But I LOVE dessert! She's got me in a bind. I get the sprout out from underneath the pile of chicken bones. It sits there – taunting me. One horrible, disgusting, moldy, old, slimy, green, putrid brussels sprout. And to make things even worse, it's cold. Mom is watching me like a hawk. So is Dad. And Jen.

JEN: Come on, Andy. Just hurry up and eat it and then we can have dessert!

ANDY: *(to Jen)* All right, all right! *(to audience)* There's only one thing to do. I'm going to have to put it in my mouth, go to the bathroom, and spit it out. And while I'm there I'll be able to get the other one out of my undies *(shifts uncomfortably)* I stab the sprout with my fork and hold it up in front of my face. Nothing is going to stop me from getting to my dessert. I put it in my mouth. *(Look of utter disgust)* YUCK! I stand up.

DAD: Where do you think you're going?

ANDY: *(with mouth full)* To the bathroom.

JEN: Don't leet him. He's not going to eat it. It's a trick! He's going to spit it out!

ANDY: *(still with a full mouth)* No, I'm not.

MOM: You can go to the bathroom AFTER you've swallowed the brussels sprout.

ANDY: But I'm BURSTING!

JEN: You mean your'e DISGUSTING!

DAD: Swallow the sprout. THEN you can go to the bathroom. That's the deal.

ANDY: *(still with mouth full)* What kind of deal is that? I eat a sprout, and I'm rewarded with a trip to the bathroom? Your deals are getting worse. I'm going to get myself a lawyer.

JEN: You don't need a lawyer. You need a psychiatrist!

DAD: He'll need a doctor if he doesn't sit down and eat that brussels sprout.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ANDY: I sit down. All eyes are on me. My escape route has been blocked. I've got the world's most disgusting brussels spout in my mouth and there's nothing I can do about it. I can't flush it down the toilet. I can't feed it to Sooty. I can't put it down my undies. There's only one thing I CAN do. It's sick! It's twisted! It's desperate! But I'm just sick, twisted and desperate enough to try it. I'm going to swallow the brussels sprout. *(look of utter disgust)* Do it or die. Okay . . . here goes. *(Straightens his spine, grips the table with both hands, closes his eyes and takes a deep breath; and another then bites down)* A watery slime oozes into my mouth. Don't think about it . . . Don't think about it. Think about nice things like sunny days . . picnics. *(Bites down again)* MORE SLIME! MORE OOZE! *(shakes head violently)* Nice things . . . like kittens and puppies . . and ponies and GIANT MASHING AND PULVERIZING MACHINES mashing them into guts and ooze and slime . . . green slime. It's probably safer to think about nothing at all. I put my mind in neutral and chew . . . *(makes the most horrible faces possible)* I can't do it . . . but I've got to. Otherwise, I don't get dessert. I might miss out on something amazing! *(continues to chew . . .then)* HEY! Wait . . . Something's happened . . . Something amazing! My mouth is no longer full. It's gone . . I must have swallowed it. I've done it! I've really done it! *(to family)* FINISHED! *(opening mouth wide to prove it is gone)*

MOM: Good job, Andy. That wasn't so bad now, was it?

ANDY: I smile and nod and try not to think about what I just did. I'll think about dessert instead. I close my eyes. I want it to be a surprise. *(so excited he can't hold still)* Maybe tonight it will be upside-down cake . . no, wait . . . pecan pie. That's my absolute favorite! No . . maybe Mom will surprise everyone and do her famous cherry pie . . . or Maybe it's chocolate fudge! Or Twinkies! Or . . . I hear Dad get something out of the fridge and put it down on the table.

JEN: Yum! My favorite!

DAD: Mmmmmm! Delicious!

MOM: I just hope it was worth the wait.

ANDY: I can't stand the suspense a moment longer. *(in words and pantomime)* I open my eyes

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and look down at the bowl in front of me. *(excited expression turns to shock and horror)* Oh no! Oh no! I don't believe it! This can't be happening. Custard – cold, horrible, disgusting, moldy, old, slimy, lumpy, yellow, putrid, vomity custard. **I HATE CUSTARD!**

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andy Griffiths
Book: Just Disgusting!
ISBN: 978-0439549547
Publisher: Scholastic, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2005

AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2018 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY